The StraightLine Insight Note — October 2026

This month's Insight Note draws on October's posts and two illustrative case studies exploring outstanding orders, delivery promises and recurring month-end expense-report corrections.

September explored what happens when system records, reporting logic and everyday operational reality do not fully agree.

October follows that investigation into the next question:

Once a report reveals something worth questioning, can the team work out what to do next?

This month's posts connected stock-count timing, delivery measures, recurring corrections and practical training. Two illustrative case studies examined outstanding orders and month-end expense-report adjustments.

Together, they show why useful reporting depends on more than identifying a difference.

The evidence needs explaining. The working practice needs understanding. And the people involved need a clear route from observation to action.

What I noticed this month

A report can show that something needs attention without giving the reader enough information to move it forward.

An order has a revised delivery date, but the latest recorded review is several weeks old.

A department's expenses have been corrected again, but the same coding template remains in use.

A delivery KPI is calculated consistently, but different readers interpret "on time" differently.

In each situation, a useful question sits just beyond the figure:

What does this mean for the person using it?

They may need supporting evidence, an agreed definition, a named owner or guidance on when to escalate.

That connection between reporting and working practice was the thread running through October.

The operational problem underneath

Information can describe the last thing that happened while leaving the next step unclear.

"Awaiting stock" explains a recorded position. It does not necessarily tell the next person who is checking availability or when another update is due.

"Department allocation amended" explains a correction. It does not establish whether the original entry, coding instructions or report logic needs changing.

Likewise, a flag needs context. A long period without recorded activity warrants investigation, but customer conversations or supply updates may be held elsewhere.

The first task is to follow the evidence far enough to understand the position. From there, the business can agree on an appropriate response.

That may involve a technical correction. It may involve a clearer timetable, better links between records or a more practical explanation of responsibilities.

The pattern behind the month

Timing changes the comparison

October began with the gap between counting stock and posting the result.

A count and a system balance may each be accurate while relating to different moments. Movements between those moments need to be controlled or reconciled before the difference can be understood.

The same principle appeared in the month-end case study: invoices had been received before the report was extracted but approval and posting happened afterwards.

Understanding the sequence matters before deciding what to change.

A shared figure needs a shared meaning

“On-time delivery” sounds clear until people explain which promise date they use, how partial deliveries are treated and whether they count orders, lines or deliveries.

Those choices affect the question the KPI answers.

A measure used to review completed deliveries may offer limited visibility of customers still waiting. Both views can be useful, provided the team understands their purpose and boundaries.

Repetition is a clue to investigate

A correction repeated every month deserves attention.

It may reveal an unresolved configuration issue or a working practice that repeatedly leaves information outside the initial report.

It may also be a necessary adjustment.

The month-end analysis made that distinction explicit: authorised utility estimates sat alongside report duplication, omitted costs and recurring allocation corrections.

The aim is to understand which work remains necessary and which causes could be addressed.

Staff need a route through the exception

Practical training includes the judgement someone needs when the usual steps no longer fit.

What should they check? What can they correct? When should they refer the issue to someone else, and what explanation should they record?

Working through one familiar exception together can reveal unclear instructions or responsibilities. Those questions are useful evidence about the process itself.

One practical check

Choose one recurring exception from a report your team uses.

Ask someone who encounters it to walk through a recent example:

1. **What drew your attention?**
   A date, amount, status, discrepancy or repeated correction?
2. **Where do you check the explanation?**
   Can you follow the figure to the relevant transaction, approval or communication?
3. **What happens next?**
   Who owns the action, and when should progress be reviewed?
4. **How will you know it is resolved?**
   What evidence or check will confirm the outcome?

Notice where the explanation becomes uncertain.

That point may give you a manageable starting place for improvement.

From the StraightLine Library

Both October case studies use synthetic datasets. They demonstrate investigation methods and proposed actions, rather than achieved client results.

Outstanding orders and changing delivery promises

The delivery case study covered 24 customers, 400 sales orders and 803 order lines, with a reporting snapshot of 30 September 2026.

The initial analysis brought together outstanding quantities, extensions to delivery promises and time since the latest recorded activity.

The deeper review followed three open order lines into their change histories. At the snapshot, their last recorded reviews were 72–79 days old.

Those records explained the earlier promise changes and what each line had been waiting for. Further checks were needed to establish whether more recent information existed elsewhere.

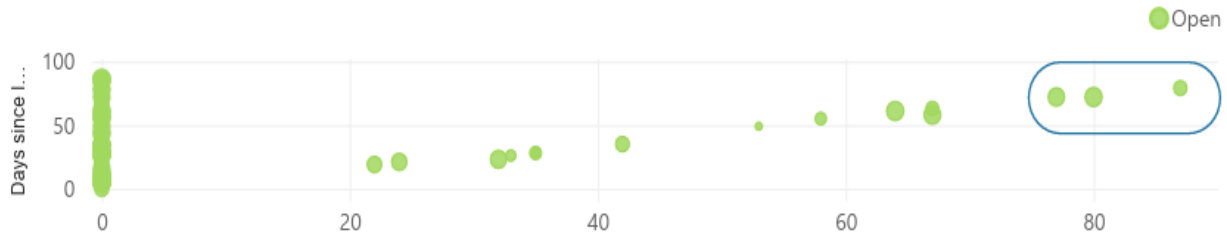
The proposed actions were to make supporting information traceable, give exceptions an owner and review date, and agree when follow-up or escalation was needed.

The useful distinction: a recorded reason explains a position; the team also needs a clear next action.

We take a look at the change history of three open order lines with 72-79 days since their last recorded activity.

Outstanding orders: changed promises and recorded inactivity

Promise extension (days), Days since last recorded activity and Outstanding Qty by OrderLineID and Current Status



OrderLineID	ProductID	Order Date	Last Activity Date	Report Date	Difference Original/Current Promise (days)	Days since last activity
SO00052-2	P005	02 July 2026	13 July 2026	30 September 2026	87	79
SO00360-2	P018	13 July 2026	20 July 2026	30 September 2026	77	72
SO00388-1	P013	10 July 2026	20 July 2026	30 September 2026	80	72

Recurring month-end expense-report corrections

The expense-report case study examined 55 adjustments across April–September 2026, with 17.6 hours of recorded preparation time.

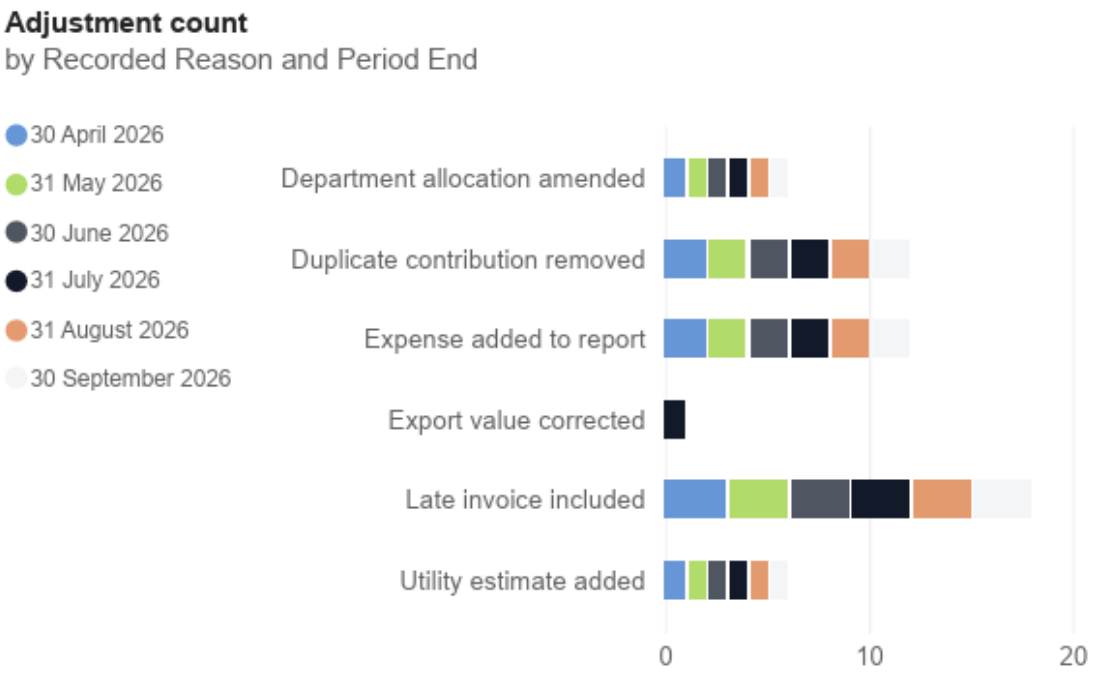
Together, the adjustments increased reported expenses by £41,280—approximately 1.3% of the initial total.

That net percentage concealed different mechanisms. Additions and reductions offset each other, while department reallocations changed individual departmental figures without changing the company total.

Supporting records identified invoice approval and posting timing, a report join producing duplicate contributions, an omitted account and a coding template that conflicted with approved allocations. Authorised utility estimates remained an expected recurring adjustment.

The recommendations addressed the close timetable, reporting and coding configurations, staff guidance and subsequent monitoring. They have not been implemented or tested within the case study, so achievable savings remain unquantified.

The useful distinction: recurring work can contain both necessary controls and causes worth correcting.



What SMEs can do next

Start with one report, one recurring problem and one question the team cannot yet answer confidently.

Agree what the investigation needs to establish. Trace an example to its supporting records and involve the people who enter, check and use the information.

Then choose a response that fits the evidence.

That could mean:

- clarifying a KPI definition;
- linking an order to its latest supporting update;
- assigning an exception owner and review date;
- testing a report join or account-inclusion rule;
- updating a coding template;
- coordinating approvals, postings and extraction;
- working through an exception with staff.

After a change, check the next reporting cycle. Has the issue reduced? Are necessary adjustments still controlled? Can the team explain the revised approach?

Improvement needs that final check.

Question for the month

When your report flags an exception, can the next person see what to check, who owns it and what happens next?

The StraightLine view

Reporting, working practices and staff understanding meet in everyday decisions.

Someone must recognise a difference, find its explanation and decide what to do with it.

Good analysis makes that decision clearer. Practical processes give it a route forward. Training helps people follow that route with confidence.

A useful report leaves the reader with a clearer next step.

How StraightLine Data & Training can help

StraightLine helps SMEs investigate reporting problems and understand the working practices behind them.

That can include tracing figures to source transactions, reviewing Power BI or SQL reporting logic, examining SAP Business One processes, clarifying definitions and helping staff recognise and handle exceptions.

A focused investigation starts by agreeing on the question and the evidence needed to answer it. The findings then provide a basis for deciding what to change, how to test it and what support the team needs.

If one reporting problem keeps returning, we can start there.

Clarity. Insight. Confidence.